

Field Journal - Day 0

August 16, 2026 - Kotagiri, Tamil Nadu

We left Bengaluru around 7:30 this morning and headed toward Mysuru. After breakfast at Maddur Tiffany's, home of the Maddur Vada, we continued toward the Nilgiris. We passed through the Bandipur and Mudumalai forests. We saw monkeys, elephants, deer, buffalo, and several birds. Seeing animals so close to the road was definitely one of the highlights of the journey.

As we climbed into the Nilgiris, the landscape became increasingly hilly and forested, with bluish mountains in the distance. That is the story behind the name Nilgiri, where *Nīli* ("blue") and *giri* ("mountain") in Kannada. Upon reaching Kotagiri, I noticed that it was very similar to a standard town in Tamil Nadu but with much more nature surrounding it. The town already feels familiar, as at dinner tonight, everyone was speaking the informal Tamil I hear at home.

I'm excited to finally begin the project, especially after spending so much time preparing my recording setup, questions, and ELAN workflow. At the same time, I'm nervous about meeting people in the villages and communicating with my limited Tamil. Fortunately, my grandmother will be there to help. Tomorrow, we will meet with the NAWA advisor and hopefully visit our first village. If everything goes well, I will make my first recordings.

Field Journal - Day 1

August 17, 2026 - Kil Kotagiri Kokkal + Puthu Kotagiri Kokkal

Today marked my first full day of fieldwork. In the morning, we visited the NAWA headquarters and met with Ms. Selvina, our guide. We discussed our visits to the several Kota communities nearby. Having someone familiar with the area is extremely valuable, especially as this is my first fieldwork experience.

Our first destination was Puthu Kotagiri ("New Kotagiri"), where we had hoped to meet Mr. Lakshmanan. He was occupied when we arrived so we continued to Kil Kotagiri Kokkal where we met several members of the community. They were all extremely welcoming, which helped alleviate some of my initial stress about interacting with community members. One of the highlights of the trip was hearing a few members of the community perform some traditional songs in Kota. I had not expected to encounter traditional Kota music on my first day, and it was particularly meaningful to experience the language through music rather than solely through a structured interview.

We were also given a tour and learned about traditional Kota pottery, which is associated with the women of that village. We later returned to Puthu Kotagiri and were able to speak with Mr. Lakshmanan, who serves as a priest at the village. He provided considerable information about Kota traditions and religious practices. One of the first things I learned was that the Kota people refer to themselves as Komanth rather than Kota. Furthermore, I learned that Kota is pronounced “Kotha,” where the “h” is removed during spelling.

He also told us about traditional clothing and religious practices. Traditional clothing for both genders is predominantly white and covers the entire body (except the head). Rather than worshipping an idol, their religious practices are centered around nature, particularly the rising sun and a lamp at night. These practices do vary between villages.

The religious sites also have specific rules governing access. Certain areas are restricted to priests, while the broader community is permitted to enter only one day per year. We were also required to remove our shoes before entering certain areas of the village, not just houses. These customs are taken very seriously, so having community members guide us was very helpful for respecting the villages.

Speaker: K01

Topic: General Interview

Notes: Speaker intermittently spoke to surrounding people, spoke very fast. Was able to come up with answers very quickly

Speaker: K02

Topic: General Interview

Notes: For this recording, I decided not to include the process of obtaining metadata as it was done in Tamil. Speaker does not switch to Tamil or English very often. Speaker uses many hand gestures while speaking about childhood but not much else. Speaker is knowledgeable about music and tradition

Speaker: K03

Topic: General Interview

Notes: Speaker spoke with less emotion than previous speakers and gave shorter answers.

Younger speaker so has younger perspectives. 2:12 - Forgot the word and asked relative for help, 3:00 - trill in voice, 4:20 - difficulty understanding question, could be due to formal Tamil, note to change

Speaker: K04

Topic: Song

Notes: A speaker wanted to sing a traditional Kota song for me. This is only sung during a festival named Kamatrayar (Ayanur amanur). Did not need a starting note or drone like typical traditional Indian classical music. Follows a typical structure: ABAB'A. Includes a few different

sections then returns to the main melody. Song also includes a rhythm played by hands on lap or claps. Song was fully in Kota, and he sang two songs.

Speaker: K05

Topic: General Interview

Notes: Born in Aghal and lives in Puthu Kotagiri. Speaker sometimes switches to Tamil - likely since questions are being asked in Tamil. As a priest he is very knowledgeable on festivals and traditions. {5:55, 7:10, 10:29} - Switches to English for a word or two

Field Journal - Day 2

August 18, 2026 - Sholur Kokkal

Today we traveled to Shorul Kokkal, located further toward Ooty for our second day of fieldwork. This village was located much further on the outskirts of the city, and thus was not as modernized. The village is known for its forgery, and we saw a blacksmith on our way into the village. Inside, they used an anvil and a pile of heated rocks to reshape metal; the tools used for farming or everyday use. They did not have a forge. The village (and the Nilgiri region) is very famous for its carrots, so we saw many large carrot farms, and people transporting bags of carrots on their heads and backs.

We met with one speaker in this village, who told us a significant amount about all of Kota life. The speaker was especially excited to show us the wide breadth of musical instruments, all of which were handcrafted by him. He had a wall filled with a double reed style instrument that resembles an oboe called the “Kombu.” He also showed us many drums that were handmade as well. Finally, the speaker showed special knives, sickles, and other harvesting tools that were made in that village’s blacksmith.

This speaker was also awarded the best tribal musician in all of Tamil Nadu for the year of 2014–2015. The unique thing about this village was its traditional architecture. While the houses had all the basic amenities on the inside, the outside did not match the newer buildings in the other Kota villages. There was also a considerably greater amount of wildlife within the Shorur Kokkal

Speaker: K06

Topic: Birth + Death

Notes: Speaker has wide range of dynamics and expressions. Also uses his hands to count lists while describing aspects of his life. 2:33 - school is in english, similar across many speakers. In Kota, the language is called “Komanth.” When speaking in English or Tamil` it is pronounced “Kotha.” 5:15 - switches to Tamil, similar to other speakers when responding to questions that

are asked in Tamil. Although online I have been told there are many glottal stops in Kota, I have yet to hear any from any speakers, unless it is too subtle and I need to see the waveform. Speaker was very enigmatic on the last question.

Field Journal - Day 3

August 19, 2026 - Thiruchikadi Kokkal + Puthu Kotagiri Kokkal

Today we visited two villages. In the morning, we headed to Thiruchigadi, located in between Ooty and Kotagiri. This was the longest village we visited, and the most vibrant. However, we were only allowed to see from the outside. This is because this week is the “Pali pooja” or milk festival. During this time, no outsiders are allowed in the village, and they are very strict about this.

We were very lucky we were able to meet a couple ladies that were not taking part in the festival. This village also had a large carrot farm and a cabbage farm. The lady we spoke to was very helpful and told us about traditional Kota marriages and jewelry.

After that we headed to Puthu Kotagiri to meet another speaker. This speaker was extremely helpful since he is a professional pottery maker. He makes a large supply of the traditional pots used in the village. We asked him many questions about pottery. He then invited us into his house and showed us a quick demonstration of shaping the pot, which was amazing to witness. He even let me try, but it was super difficult and my pot broke. He made it look so easy.

The speaker showed us the tools he uses and a large sample of his recent works, all of which were very unique and interesting.

Speaker: K07

Topic: Marriage + Jewelry

Notes: Currently in this village a “pooja” (festival) is ongoing, Because of this, we were not allowed in the village and they were not allowed out. We had one lady uninvolved with the pooja meet us outside the village because of this. I noted that like many Dravidian language speakers, Kota speakers use English and Tamil words intermittently because there is no direct English translation [in many cases]

Speaker: K08

Topic: Pottery

Notes: In Puthu Kotagiri Kokkal, speaking with a professional pottery master and teacher. Speaker has painted nails, perhaps due to his profession. [When asked later, speaker said it was a tradition for Kota men to have orange/brown painted nails on the hand(s) used for work] Speaker

wears modern non-traditional clothing, and uses hand motions to describe only the process of making traditional pots

Field Journal - Day 4

August 20, 2026 - Kollimalai Kokkal

Today we headed to the fifth and final village (total 7) that is nearby Kotagiri. It's name is Kollimalai Kokkal, and is located in between Ooty and Coonoor, two major cities in Tamil Nadu. The village was located quite high up on the mountain, compared to the low and medium heights of the other villages.

Once we arrived, the Keri system used in Kota communities was very apparent. Essentially, a Keri is a street or cluster of homes that act as one political/social group. We learned that people cannot marry within their Keri, and each Keri plays a specific role in making important decisions.

Once we arrived at the village, we asked locals for directions to the tribal leader's home. At the house, we learned he was not there, but another local offered to call him. We asked for permission on the phone to interview a member of the community. He agreed, however the others were very unsure. They said that they needed the leader, or the head priest to be present during it.

Fortunately, one passerby spoke to us and agreed, and invited us into his home for the interview. He was really helpful in learning more about the Kota social structure and music. He even showed us all 7 types of Kota instruments, including a long curved horn called the Kobu.

Speaker: K09

Topic: Social structure + Music

Notes: Speaker is holding a traditional but very ornate tool used for agriculture that was manufactured by him, as he is a blacksmith. The speaker also has painted nails (same color and material) as yesterday's speaker, this time on both hands rather than just the left. 1:00 uses english words for languages (Tamil, English, Hindi). Is knowledgeable about music, told us that moist people in the Kota community can sing or play instruments.
